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Tenants smarting from rent control failure

Conditions that led to ballot question haven't gone away

By Andrew Brinker

GLOBE STAFF

Like many Greater Boston residents, Michelle Harrison's life revolves around her monthly rent payment.

She has moved from town to town in Eastern Massachusetts over the past decade in search of something affordable. And when she lost

her job as an office coordinator last month, her first thought was: "How am I going to afford rent?"

Harrison, 33, had pinned her hopes for relief on rent control. As a push to cap rent increases for the first time in decades appeared to gain steam this year, she found herself picturing what life might look like without the specter of the annual rent hikes that have squeezed her budget ever-tighter.

"My rent is up \$1,000 from when I moved in six years ago," said Harrison, who now shares an apartment in Norwood with two roommates.

"That is not sustainable. And rent control could stop it."

She will have to keep waiting.

The state Supreme Judicial Court last month threw out a ballot question that would have installed rent control across Massachusetts for the first time since the 1990s, dealing a sharp blow to the hundreds of thousands of everyday renters who, like Harrison, often struggle to afford sky-high rents.

The question — which would have limited annual rent increases in most apartment buildings statewide to the pace of inflation — had

gathered enough momentum to bring powerful real estate groups to the bargaining table to discuss a compromise.

Renters were the force behind it.

Many young people here have friends who have decamped for cheaper areas. Young people who were sold a dream of homeownership are grappling with the reality that they may end up renting forever. Rent growth has so dramatically outpaced income gains in recent decades that some 250,000 renters, nearly half of all the renters in the

RENTERS, Page A6

Platner still in but hopefuls line up

Maine Democrats already focused on next nominee

By Sam Brodey

GLOBE STAFF

Graham Platner hasn't yet announced whether he'll continue his Senate campaign in Maine following a bombshell rape allegation that landed Monday.

Maine Democrats, however, are rapidly moving forward without him.

Under Maine law, Platner can be replaced as the Democratic nominee if he withdraws before July 13 — which seems increasingly inevitable as his support collapses across the party.

The party would then have until July 27 to select a replacement. But there is no obvious existing procedure for this situation — leaving Democratic officials scrambling to devise a process to replace Platner that is fair, open, and can be concluded in time.

Meanwhile, at least a half-dozen possible contenders waiting in the wings are competing for position and letting news media know they are receiving supportive calls.

Progressive and moderate factions both in and outside Maine are escalating online battles that have become nasty, demanding the other side be blocked from influencing who succeeds Platner as nominee.

For voters, activists, and even potential candidates, it's a heady mix, and one without precedent

PLATNER, Page A5

WORKING OUT THE BUGS IN EFFORT TO SLOW WARMING



PHOTOS BY FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Kathleen Savage, a scientist at Woodwell Climate Research Center, is collecting data in Edinburg, Maine.

Methane-eating microbes could help with potent greenhouse gas



Savage was joined by Logan Quinn as they sampled the canopy.

By Sabrina Shankman

GLOBE STAFF

HOWLAND, MAINE

Scientist Kathleen Savage leaned out from the basket of a boom lift, a red safety helmet perched on her head.

She sealed a few needle-covered stalks from an Eastern Hemlock tree inside a clear plastic cylinder and pulled out her phone. On the screen, a meter rose and fell as the level of gases inside the cylinder fluctuated. The question she was asking: What were the microscopic bugs on the stalks and leaves doing in there?

The answer would provide limited data — just one point, from one portion of a tree in one forest.

But looked at another way, it could also buy the planet critical time as the world races to address the climate crisis.

"These small, microscopic organisms are everywhere," she said. "When you translate that to an entire forest, they add up and pack a big punch."

METHANE, Page A7

Brigham nurses poised to strike today, for a day

Would be largest in state history; hospital planning to follow with a lockout

By Marin Wolf and Jonathan Saltzman

GLOBE STAFF

About 4,000 unionized nurses at Brigham and Women's Hospital are slated to walk off the job Wednesday in what would be the largest nurses strike in Massachusetts history.

The threatened strike follows months of negotiations between the Massachusetts Nurses Association and the state's largest health care system. Talks ended after the two sides hit an impasse over pay increases and health insurance costs at the Harvard teaching hospital.

The strike is only scheduled to last one day, but nurses will be locked out of the hospital an additional four days, returning on July 13. That's because Brigham, one of Mass General Brigham's two flagship hospitals, is contractually obligated to provide the temporary replacement nurses that it has hired with five days of work, MGB told staff.

The dispute has the potential to disrupt care and expose discord at one of the state's most prominent and highly rated hospitals. MGB representa-

STRIKE, Page A6

Wrong-way crashes on the rise in Mass.

State makes changes to road signs, adds cameras

By Diti Kohli and Scooty Nickerson

GLOBE STAFF

A Massachusetts state trooper, already off duty, killed responding to an errant Jeep. A Gloucester teenager, newly graduated from high school, struck head-on on Route 128. And a Haverhill man, mangled in the aftermath of a collision while driving down Interstate 93.

These are just three lives claimed by wrong-way car crashes that are increasingly common in Massachusetts.

The trifecta of fatal accidents in the final days of June, followed by yet another Monday, underscores how the problem has metastasized in Massachusetts: Citations for wrong-way driving have exploded in recent years, and the number of deaths climbed.

In each of the last two years, the state issued

ACCIDENTS, Page A7



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Signage on southbound Route 128 onto High Street in Danvers seems clear.



Heady mercury

Wednesday: Sun's back, nice. High 73-78. Low 65-70.

Thursday: Hot and humid. High 85-90. Low 70-75.

High tide: 5:46 a.m., 6:11 p.m. Sunrise: 5:15 Sunset: 8:23

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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President Trump insisted that the United States should be in control of Greenland rather than NATO ally Denmark. **A3.**

The tall ships are coming, so it's time to brush up on nautical words and phrases. **B1.**

A local sheriff criticized ICE after the agency accused his office of ignoring its request to hold a New Bedford man facing charges. **B1.**

The Museum of American Finance has opened in the Seaport, eight years after its New York headquarters was flooded out. **B5.**

Not every Boston-area restaurant has to be a splurge. Devra First finds some alternatives that offer a similar experience for less. **G1.**